

HAMSTER · *MESOCRICETUS AURATUS*

Keep your hamster the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the enclosure and bedding depth the starter kit gets wrong, species differences, wet tail triage, and the routines that matter in a life this short.

22 pages

Beginner friendly

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 9 in order before buying anything, and read page 5 before you buy the cage. Enclosure footprint and bedding depth are one decision, not two, because most cages sold for hamsters physically cannot hold the depth this species needs. Getting that wrong means buying the cage twice. Then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 16.

If your hamster is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Environment Targets on page 14 to audit what you have. If your hamster chews the cage bars, go to page 9 first, that is a husbandry readout rather than a personality trait. And if you see watery diarrhea or a wet rear end, stop reading and call a vet today. Page 11 explains why.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 14: Setup Checklist & Environment Targets | ☐ Page 19: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 15: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 20: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 18: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 21: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Hamster housing standards have moved a long way in a short time, and the small wire cages still sold as starter kits fall well short of current welfare guidance. This package reflects the peer-reviewed bedding depth and cage size research on pages 5 and 9, and the large veterinary study behind the health section, rather than what comes printed on the box.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An exotics-experienced veterinarian. Hamsters have fast metabolisms and short lives, which means conditions progress in days rather than weeks. Anything urgent is a vet call today, not a page in this book.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail. Figures are for the Syrian unless noted.

Scientific name	Mesocricetus auratus, the Syrian or golden hamster
Adult size	5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm), 4 to 7 oz. Dwarf species are smaller
Captive lifespan	Median 1.75 years across species, extending to about 3.65. Syrians 2 to 3, dwarfs 1.5 to 2.5
Native range	Arid steppe and farmland, northern Syria and southern Turkey
Diet type	Omnivore; pellets or lab blocks with fresh vegetables and occasional protein
Enclosure minimum	700 to 775 sq in unbroken floor for a Syrian, about 600 for dwarfs
Social needs	Syrians are strictly solitary. Housing two together leads to fighting
Handling difficulty	Beginner for Syrians; dwarfs are faster and more nip-prone
Conservation status	Vulnerable (IUCN), for the wild Syrian population

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$150 to \$350 for enclosure, deep bedding, a solid wheel, hideout, sand bath, dishes, and chew items. The animal itself is \$15 to \$30, or \$5 to \$15 from a rescue.

Monthly ongoing

\$15 to \$50. Food is only \$5 to \$12 of that; bedding and sand refills are the bigger recurring cost at \$15 to \$30, because deep bedding has to be replaced to stay clean.

THE COST PICTURE IS BACKWARDS FROM THE STICKER PRICE

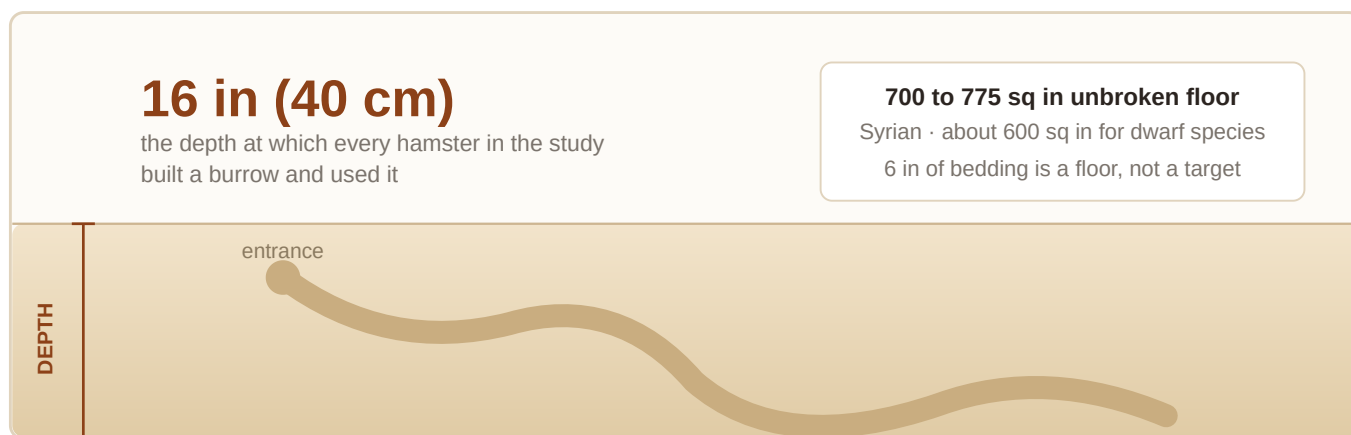
A humane setup costs roughly ten times what the animal costs, which is exactly what makes hamsters so easy to underfund. Budget \$100 to \$800 for emergency care too, most urgently for wet tail, and \$40 to \$80 for a routine exotic exam.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Nearly every pet Syrian alive today descends from a single wild-caught female found near Aleppo in 1930, and the litter she was carrying.
- Cheek pouches hold roughly a fifth of a hamster's own body weight in food, which is why you may not see one eat for a day and it is still perfectly fine.
- In the wild they are solitary burrowers digging extensive tunnel systems, and fiercely territorial toward other hamsters. That trait carries straight into captivity.
- They are nocturnal. Reaching in during the day to a deeply asleep hamster is the single most common way new owners get bitten.

Enclosure size & bedding depth

These are one decision, not two. Current welfare guidance calls for roughly 700 to 775 square inches of unbroken floor space for a Syrian and around 600 for dwarf species, with more always better. But the depth of bedding a cage can physically hold matters just as much, and most cages sold for hamsters cannot hold what the research says this species needs. Choose the cage around the bedding, not the other way round.



Unbroken floor space. Levels and tubes do not count toward it.
Bar spacing: no more than 1/2 in for Syrians, 1/4 in for dwarfs, Roborovski especially.

THE STUDY BEHIND THE NUMBER

Hauzenberger, Gebhardt-Henrich and Steiger gave 45 golden hamsters either 80, 40 or 10 cm of wood shavings. The 10 cm group showed significantly more wire-gnawing and higher wheel activity. Every hamster given at least 40 cm built a burrow and used it. In the 80 cm group, wire-gnawing was not observed at all.

What that means in practice

- Six inches is the commonly quoted minimum and is genuinely better than a cage liner, but it is below the depth at which burrowing behavior actually appears. Treat it as the floor and go deeper where the enclosure allows.
- Bin cages and large glass tanks hold depth that wire cages cannot. A 40-gallon breeder works for dwarfs; Syrians do better in a 75-gallon or equivalent.
- Mix a burrow-holding material with a looser one so tunnels stay up instead of collapsing. That is the difference between a hamster that digs and one that just redecorates.

The wheel, the sand bath & the rest

Bedding material

Dust-free paper-based bedding or aspen shavings. Both hold a burrow and neither irritates the airway. Avoid cedar and pine entirely: the aromatic oils in both are a documented respiratory irritant, and dusty bedding is one of the most common causes of the respiratory infections on page 12. Avoid cotton-style fluffy nesting material too, which wraps around limbs.

The wheel

Solid-surface with no rungs, because wire and mesh wheels cause foot injuries. Size it so the back stays flat rather than arched while running: at least 8 to 11 inches for a Syrian, 6 to 8 for a dwarf. A wheel that is too small forces a permanently curved running posture that is not good for the spine over time.

DON'T READ THE ODOMETER AS A WELFARE SCORE

In the bedding study, the hamsters on the shallowest bedding ran *more*, alongside chewing the bars more. Heavy wheel use can accompany a poor setup rather than prove a good one. Provide the wheel, but judge the enclosure by whether the animal burrows, not by how far it runs.

The sand bath, which most kits leave out

A dust-free, non-clumping sand bath is a species essential, not an optional extra. Hamsters use it to manage coat and skin oils the way a bird uses a dust bath, and skipping it is not a minor omission. Use children's play sand or reptile-safe sand that is explicitly dust-free, never clumping cat litter, and refresh it as it gets soiled.

Temperature

65 to 75°F, kept stable. Below 60°F risks torpor, a hibernation-like state that can be dangerous (page 13). Above 80°F risks heat stress. No supplemental heat is needed indoors, but a thermometer beats guessing.

Lighting

No special lighting or UVB. A normal day and night cycle is enough. This is a nocturnal species, so bright light during their active hours is disruptive rather than helpful.

Rounding out the enclosure

- ☐ Hideout, so the hamster is never fully exposed
- ☐ Food dish, plus scatter-feeding around the enclosure
- ☐ Connected tunnels and cover across open ground
- ☐ Valveless sipper bottle, checked daily for leaks
- ☐ Chew items to wear continuously growing incisors
- ☐ Timothy hay as a chewing supplement, not a diet base

Species differences & handling

Temperament varies more by species here than most people expect. A Syrian and a Roborovski, both sold under the same "hamster" label, are genuinely different pets to hold.

SPECIES	HANDLING	WHAT TO KNOW
Syrian (golden, teddy bear)	Easiest, least likely to nip once settled	Strictly solitary. Must be housed alone
Winter White, Campbell's, Chinese dwarf	Quicker, more easily startled, real chance of nipping	Campbell's and Chinese are diabetes-prone
Roborovski dwarf	Fastest, least suited to regular handling	Tends to bite and cling rather than nip cleanly

PICK THE SPECIES FOR THE RELATIONSHIP YOU ACTUALLY WANT

If handling matters to you, choose a Syrian. If you mainly want an active pet to watch, a dwarf, and a Roborovski especially, is better as an observation animal than a hold-and-pet one. Neither choice is wrong. Choosing without knowing the difference is where people get disappointed.

Getting handling right

Approach calmly and let the hamster wake and orient itself before you reach in. Scoop from below with both hands cupped rather than grabbing from above, which reads as a predator strike. Stay low, or work over a soft surface: hamsters are quick, and a jump from chest height is a fall. Keep early sessions short and let the animal walk onto your hand rather than lifting it out.

MOST BITES ARE AN AMBUSH FROM THE HAMSTER'S POINT OF VIEW

They are nocturnal. Reaching into the cage during the day while your hamster is deeply asleep is the single most reliable way to get bitten, and it is not aggression, it is a startled, disoriented animal defending itself.

First-timer mistakes

- Reaching in during the day while the hamster is asleep.
- Cornering or trapping a hamster that is trying to get away.
- Expecting a Roborovski to behave like a Syrian.
- Housing two Syrians together so they have company. They will fight, and this is one of the most common and most preventable hamster-owner mistakes there is.

Diet & feeding

Hamsters are omnivores that hoard. Both halves of that matter: what goes in the bowl, and the fact that you often will not see it eaten.

Schedule, where sources genuinely disagree

This is worth knowing rather than presenting as settled. Some veterinary sources treat pelleted food as something that stays continuously available, since hamsters are natural hoarders and rarely overeat pellets. Others describe twice-daily measured feedings, roughly 2 tablespoons a day for a standard-size hamster and about 1 tablespoon for a dwarf, with a broader 1/8 to 1/3 cup range appearing elsewhere. Both approaches are legitimate. Pick one, stay consistent, and keep fresh water available either way.

COMPONENT	AMOUNT	FREQUENCY
Pellets or lab blocks	The diet base	Free-choice or twice daily, your choice consistently applied
Fresh vegetables	About 1 teaspoon	Daily
Fruit	About 1 teaspoon	Roughly 3 times a week
Fresh food total	Under about 10% of the diet	Vegetables and fruit combined
Treats (seeds, nuts, popcorn)	Under 5 to 10% of the total	1 to 2 times a week

Pellets, not a loose seed mix

Hamsters selectively eat the sugary, fatty pieces from a muesli-style mix and leave the fiber-rich ones, which is linked to dental problems and obesity. A seed-only diet is specifically flagged as too high in fat and nutritionally poor.

Scatter, don't just fill a bowl

Hide food around the enclosure rather than serving it in one place. It turns a two-minute event into a foraging session and engages the hoarding behavior that is core to the species. It also costs nothing.

Safe and unsafe

Safe, in moderation: broccoli, cucumber, bell pepper, kale, spinach, peas, zucchini, carrot; apple with seeds removed, banana, melon, pear; mealworms, boiled unseasoned egg, small amounts of nuts and seeds, plain pasta, unsalted popcorn, and timothy hay.

NEVER FEED

Grapes and rhubarb, both explicitly flagged as poisonous to rodents. Raw onion and raw garlic carry a real hemolytic anemia risk. Chocolate, bitter almonds (distinct from ordinary sweet almonds, a frequent point of confusion), raw kidney beans, raw potato, eggplant, and avocado are all named as unsafe. Citrus is genuinely disputed: some sources avoid it outright, others allow it occasionally for Syrians, with extra caution for diabetes-prone dwarfs either way.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Buying the starter kit, which is usually undersized in footprint and cannot hold usable bedding depth in the first place.
- Adding accessories to a shallow setup and calling it enriched. The behavior that changed in the study changed with depth, not with toys.
- Housing two Syrians together for company.
- Cedar or pine bedding, or any dusty substrate, which drives the respiratory infections on page 12.
- A wire or undersized wheel, which causes foot injuries and an arched running posture.
- Skipping the sand bath, which is a species essential rather than a nice extra.
- A treat-heavy or seed-heavy diet, which feeds directly into obesity, dental disease, and diabetes risk in dwarf species.
- Letting the room drop below 60°F, which risks torpor (page 13).

BAR-CHEWING IS A READOUT, NOT A PERSONALITY TRAIT

Wire-gnawing is a standard behavioral measure used to assess housing quality in small rodents, which is exactly why the bedding study tracked it. A hamster chewing the bars is not bored in a vague sense, it is displaying a behavior that decreases when the animal can burrow properly.

Enrichment, by priority

1. Bedding deep enough for a real burrow

40 cm as the floor, more where the enclosure allows. This is the item with a study behind it, and it outranks everything below it.

3. A correctly sized solid wheel

Necessary, but not sufficient, and not a substitute for depth. Flat back while running, solid surface, no rungs.

5. Scatter feeding and foraging

Hiding food around the enclosure rather than bowl-feeding. Free, and directly engages hoarding behavior.

2. A cage that makes that possible

Footprint and wall height are the constraint that decides whether depth is even achievable. Cage choice and bedding depth are the same decision.

4. Connected cover and tunnels

Hamsters are prey animals and cross open ground reluctantly. Cover changes how much of the enclosure gets used at all, and a large cage the animal won't cross is a small cage.

6. Novelty objects, last

Worth adding, worth rotating, and worth nothing if the bedding is shallow.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

SAME-DAY VET IF YOU SEE

Watery diarrhea or a wet, matted rear end, which is wet tail until proven otherwise · labored breathing or wheezing · discharge from the eyes or nose · a swollen abdomen · seizures · a lump or growth · a hunched, lethargic posture · noticeable weight loss · one-sided facial swelling with drooling

Why the clock runs faster here

A hamster's metabolism is fast and its life is short. A large veterinary study found a median age at death of just 1.75 years. Conditions that would give you weeks of warning in a larger pet give you days here, and wet tail specifically can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours. Waiting to see whether something improves is a strategy that works badly in this species.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Species and approximate age, since risk profiles differ sharply
- ☐ Weight now and at your last few log entries
- ☐ Exactly what the droppings look like, and when they changed
- ☐ Bedding type and when it was last fully changed
- ☐ Room temperature, and whether it has dropped recently
- ☐ Any recent stressor: transport, a new home, a diet change, a cage change

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Not seeing your hamster eat for a day, while it is otherwise active and a hoard exists	Visibly refusing available fresh food, especially alongside lethargy or diarrhea
Sleeping deeply and immovably through the day	Cold, stiff and unresponsive with shallow breathing, which is torpor (page 13)
Full cheek pouches, sometimes comically so	One-sided pouch swelling with face-pawing, drooling, or sudden disinterest in collecting food
Bedding rearranged nightly and food cached in odd corners	Persistent bar-chewing, which points at the setup rather than the animal

Wet tail, the one to know

THIS IS A SAME-DAY EMERGENCY

Wet tail can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours without treatment. Do not wait to see whether it improves. If you see watery diarrhea and a wet or matted rear end, call a vet today.

What it is

Proliferative ileitis, a bacterial condition of the small intestine, strongly tied to stress. A large veterinary study tracking causes of death in pet hamsters found it to be both the most commonly diagnosed condition in the species and its leading specific cause of death, present in roughly 7 to 8% of the hamsters studied. It hits young Syrians between 3 and 10 weeks old hardest, which is exactly the age most hamsters are sold.

Cause, signs and response

Cause: bacterial, triggered by stress. Transport, overcrowding, poor hygiene, and sudden diet change are the named triggers, which is why the risk window sits right around the move to a new home. **Signs:** watery diarrhea, a wet or matted rear end, lethargy, and a hunched posture. **Diagnosis:** clinical exam, with the vet asking directly about recent stressors and diet changes. **Response:** immediate veterinary treatment, typically antibiotics plus fluid support, since dehydration is what kills fastest. **Recovery:** possible when caught early, poor once the animal is already collapsed. Treatment cost runs \$100 to \$800 depending on severity.

PREVENTION IS MOSTLY THE FIRST TWO WEEKS

Keep the new-home period as low-stress as possible: minimal handling, no cage changes, no diet change from what the seller was feeding, and scrupulous hygiene. If you are going to switch foods, do it gradually and after the hamster has settled, not on day one. The same rule applies any time you change something significant later.

DON'T CONFUSE IT WITH ORDINARY SOFT DROPPINGS

A single soft dropping after a new vegetable is not wet tail. Wet tail is watery, continuous, and comes with a visibly wet rear end and a hamster that has gone quiet and hunched. If you are genuinely unsure, treat it as wet tail and call. The cost of being wrong in that direction is a vet bill; the cost of being wrong in the other direction is the animal.

Dental disease, tumors & respiratory infection

Overgrown incisors (malocclusion)

Cause: hamster incisors grow continuously, so a lack of appropriate chew items lets them overgrow. Less commonly it is genetic, or follows a jaw injury. **Signs:** dropped food, drooling, weight loss, and a hamster that approaches food then backs off. **Response:** a vet trims the teeth; this is not a home job. **Prevention:** chew items and timothy hay, plus a pellet base rather than soft foods. Dental pain is cited as the single most common cause of appetite refusal in this species, which makes it worth checking before you assume something rarer.

Tumors

Cause: largely age, and they are more common in females. **Signs:** a visible or palpable lump, sometimes with weight loss or a change in activity. **Reality check:** tumors grow quickly here because everything in a hamster runs fast, and they are one of the more frequent causes of death in aging hamsters. **Response:** always a vet visit. Some are operable and some are not, and the answer depends on location and the animal's age more than on size at discovery.

Respiratory infection

Cause: drafts, damp conditions, and dusty bedding, with sawdust, cedar, and pine named specifically. **Signs:** sneezing, wheezing, labored breathing, and discharge from the eyes or nose. **Response:** always a vet, since this does not clear on its own in an animal this small. **Prevention:** clean, dust-free paper-based bedding removes the most common trigger outright, and a thermometer and hygrometer confirm the room is not running colder or damper than you think.

THE HUSBANDRY PATTERN WORTH REMEMBERING

Stress and poor hygiene drive wet tail. Dusty or aromatic bedding drives respiratory disease. A sugar-heavy diet drives diabetes risk in dwarf species. All three sit fully within an owner's control, and given how short a hamster's life already is, the basics matter more here than they would in a longer-lived pet.

Diabetes, torpor & cheek pouch impaction

Diabetes, mostly a dwarf problem

Cause: a documented susceptibility in Campbell's and Chinese dwarf hamsters, made worse by sugary treats, honey sticks, and fruit-heavy diets. **Signs:** excessive drinking and urination alongside weight loss, often with wetter bedding around the water bottle as the first thing an owner actually notices. **Response:** a vet-guided low-sugar diet, which manages it well in most cases. **Prevention:** a plain formulated pellet or lab block as the base, and treating sugary treats as an occasional exception rather than a daily habit. If you keep a Campbell's or a Chinese, assume the risk applies and feed accordingly from the start.

Cold-induced torpor

Cause: room temperature dropping below roughly 65°F, and especially below 60°F. **Signs:** minimal activity, little or no eating, and a hamster that is cold, stiff, and barely breathing. It looks alarmingly like death, and owners have buried living animals over this. **Response:** gradual warming, slowly and steadily rather than with direct heat, and a vet call if the hamster does not rouse. **Note:** this is distinct from true hibernation, which pet hamsters do not undergo. **Prevention:** keep the room in the 65 to 75°F band and check it in winter rather than assuming.

Cheek pouch impaction

Cause: soft or moist food clumping and lodging in a pouch. Uncommon, but distinctive once you know it. **Signs:** one-sided facial swelling, face-pawing, drooling, and a sudden loss of interest in collecting food. **Response:** a vet, who will flush or empty the pouch. Do not attempt this yourself, pouch tissue is delicate. **Prevention:** avoid sticky or very moist foods as scatter items, and keep fresh food portions small enough to be eaten rather than stored.

QUICK DIFFERENTIATOR

A hamster that is asleep is warm, breathing normally, and rouses within a minute or two of gentle disturbance. A hamster in torpor is cold to the touch, stiff, and slow to respond to anything. If you are not sure which you are looking at, warm the room gradually and watch. Do not shake the animal.

Setup checklist & environment targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 700 to 775 sq in unbroken floor (about 600 for dwarfs)
- ☐ Bar spacing 1/2 in max for Syrians, 1/4 in for dwarfs
- ☐ A second, looser bedding to keep tunnels from collapsing
- ☐ Dust-free, non-clumping sand bath
- ☐ Valveless sipper bottle and a food dish
- ☐ Digital thermometer for the room
- ☐ Walls tall enough to hold deep bedding
- ☐ Dust-free paper bedding or aspen, 6 in floor, deeper is better
- ☐ Solid-surface wheel, 8 to 11 in for Syrians, 6 to 8 for dwarfs
- ☐ Hideout, plus connected tunnels and cover
- ☐ Chew items and timothy hay
- ☐ Carrier for vet trips

Environment targets

TARGET	RANGE
Room temperature	65 to 75°F, kept stable
Torpor risk below	60°F
Heat stress risk above	80°F
Bedding depth, commonly quoted minimum	6 in
Bedding depth for reliable burrowing	16 in (40 cm) or more
Floor space, Syrian / dwarf	700 to 775 sq in / about 600 sq in
Wheel diameter, Syrian / dwarf	8 to 11 in / 6 to 8 in
Lighting	Normal day and night cycle, no UVB

Before your hamster comes home

- ☐ Enclosure fully set up, bedding in and levelled, before pickup day
- ☐ Same food the seller was using, so nothing changes on day one
- ☐ A quiet location chosen, away from daytime foot traffic
- ☐ Room confirmed inside 65 to 75°F with a thermometer
- ☐ Exotics-experienced vet identified, with their hours noted
- ☐ Everyone in the house briefed: no handling for the first week

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A VET TODAY IF

Watery diarrhea or a wet, matted rear end · labored breathing or wheezing · discharge from eyes or nose · a lump or growth · a swollen abdomen · seizures · hunched, lethargic posture · noticeable weight loss · one-sided facial swelling with drooling · cold and stiff with shallow breathing

READING	TARGET
Room temperature	65 to 75°F
Below this, torpor risk	60°F
Above this, heat stress risk	80°F
Bedding depth	6 in floor, 16 in for real burrowing
Floor space, Syrian	700 to 775 sq in unbroken
No food at all, watch closely	6 to 12 hours
No food at all, vet call	12 to 24 hours, or sooner with any other symptom
No food at all, critical	24 hours; 48 hours is life-threatening

THE HOARDING CAVEAT ON THOSE HOURS

Those thresholds are for genuinely no food access. Because hamsters cache food in pouches and around the enclosure, you may not witness eating for a day or more, and some hamsters run on a stash for three to four days, while being completely fine. The emergency is a hamster visibly refusing available fresh food while showing other symptoms.

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Species and age, current weight and the trend from your log, what the droppings look like, room temperature, bedding type and last change, and any recent stressor or diet change.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
The hamster itself (Syrian)	\$15 to \$25
Dwarf species (Winter White, Campbell's, Roborovski, Chinese)	\$8 to \$30
Rescue or adoption	\$5 to \$15
Enclosure (bin, wire, or glass tank)	\$30 to \$90
Solid exercise wheel	\$15 to \$30
Bedding, initial deep fill	\$20 to \$35
Hideout	\$10 to \$15
Food and water dishes, sipper bottle	\$10 to \$15
Digital thermometer	\$10 to \$15
Sand bath, chew items, tunnels, carrier	Remainder of the range
Total initial setup	\$150 to \$350
Pellets or lab blocks (annual)	\$30 to \$50
Fresh vegetables (annual)	\$20 to \$40
Bedding replacement (annual)	\$60 to \$100
Chew toys and wood blocks (annual)	\$15 to \$25
Annual exotic wellness check	\$40 to \$80
Monthly ongoing	\$15 to \$50

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The enclosure and the bedding. They are the two line items the research on pages 5 and 9 speaks to directly, and they are the two most starter kits get wrong. Save on decor and novelty items before you save here.

PLAN FOR THE EMERGENCY, NOT JUST THE MONTH

Emergency care runs \$100 to \$800, most urgently for wet tail, and it tends to arrive early rather than late in a hamster's life. A small emergency fund matters more here than the monthly figure does.

First 30 days checklist

The first two weeks are also the peak wet tail risk window. Low stress is the goal, not a fast bond.

Week 1

- ☐ No handling at all. Fresh water, food, and spot-cleaning only
- ☐ Keep the same food the seller was using, with no diet change
- ☐ Check droppings daily. This is the wet tail window (page 11)
- ☐ Confirm room temperature sits inside 65 to 75°F

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Start hand-taming: sit near the enclosure during active hours, offer food from an open palm
- ☐ First short pickups only once the hamster comes to your hand willingly
- ☐ Book a wellness check with an exotics-experienced vet
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 20, including weight

Week 4

- ☐ Review the weight trend. Steady or gently rising is the goal
- ☐ If switching foods, begin the transition gradually now, not earlier
- ☐ Top up bedding depth. It compacts noticeably in the first month
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 21, one at a time

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Watch for bar-chewing and treat it as a depth problem before a boredom problem
- ☐ Check incisor length during a handling session; dropped food is the early sign
- ☐ Look back at the log for slow drift in weight rather than single readings
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 21

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Watery diarrhea, wet or matted rear end	Wet tail	Vet today, do not wait (page 11)
Dropped food, drooling, weight loss	Overgrown incisors	Vet for trimming (page 12)
Lump or visible growth	Tumor	Vet visit, especially in an older female (page 12)
Sneezing, wheezing, discharge	Respiratory infection	Vet; switch to dust-free bedding (page 12)
Drinking and urinating heavily, losing weight	Diabetes, dwarf species	Vet; low-sugar diet (page 13)
Cold, stiff, barely breathing	Torpor, room too cold	Warm gradually, vet if no rousing (page 13)
One-sided facial swelling, face-pawing	Cheek pouch impaction	Vet; do not attempt at home (page 13)
Persistent bar-chewing	Bedding too shallow	Increase depth before adding toys (page 9)
Not seen eating for a day, otherwise active	Working through a hoard	Usually normal, keep watching (page 15)
Refusing available food with lethargy	Several possible causes	Vet call, bring the Owner Log (page 20)
Sore or swollen feet	Wire wheel or wire flooring	Switch to a solid surface, vet if open (page 6)
Biting when picked up	Startled, usually woken during the day	Handle during active hours only (page 7)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Fresh water, and check the sipper bottle is not leaking or blocked
- ☐ Feed, scattering rather than only filling a dish
- ☐ Remove uneaten fresh food before it spoils in a cache
- ☐ Spot-clean the latrine corner
- ☐ Quick visual check: rear end, breathing, posture, activity

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh and log, on the same day each week
- ☐ Refresh or sift the sand bath
- ☐ Top up bedding where it has compacted or been dug out
- ☐ Check the wheel runs freely and the surface is intact
- ☐ Check incisors and feet during a handling session

Monthly

- ☐ Partial bedding change, leaving some scent-marked material behind so the enclosure still smells like home
- ☐ Scrub the water bottle and dishes properly
- ☐ Reposition or add one piece of cover or a tunnel section
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for slow trends rather than single readings

Seasonal

- ☐ Check the room in winter. A cold snap is what puts a hamster into torpor (page 13)
- ☐ Watch for heat stress in summer, especially in a room that gets afternoon sun
- ☐ Re-check bar spacing and enclosure fit as a young hamster finishes growing

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	ROOM °F	DROPPINGS	ACTIVITY	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

In an animal with a median life of under two years, a slow weight change is the difference between catching something and missing it. Weekly weight is the single most useful number you can write down, and it is the first thing a vet will ask for.

Bedding & cleaning log

DATE	WHAT WAS DONE	DEPTH AFTER

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Bedding deep enough to hold a burrow that does not collapse
- ☐ A mix of burrow-holding and looser material
- ☐ Correctly sized solid wheel, flat back while running
- ☐ Connected tunnels and cover so open floor gets crossed
- ☐ Dust-free sand bath
- ☐ Chew items in more than one texture

Monthly review

- ☐ Scatter-feed rather than bowl-feed, and vary where you hide food
- ☐ Add or move one tunnel section or hide
- ☐ Check whether the hamster is using more of the enclosure than last month
- ☐ Check for bar-chewing, and treat any as a depth problem first

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't house Syrians together. Don't use a wire or mesh wheel, or one small enough to arch the back. Don't read heavy wheel running as proof the setup works, the study found the opposite pattern. Don't use cotton-style fluffy nesting material, which wraps around limbs. And don't add accessories to a shallow setup and call it enriched.

Enrichment log

DATE	CHANGE MADE	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Wet tail	Proliferative ileitis: a stress-linked bacterial intestinal infection, the leading specific cause of death in pet hamsters.
Torpor	A cold-induced, hibernation-like state below about 60 to 65°F. Dangerous, and easily mistaken for death.
Malocclusion	Misaligned or overgrown teeth. Hamster incisors grow continuously and need wear or trimming.
Cheek pouch	The paired internal pouches a hamster carries food in, holding roughly a fifth of its body weight.
Wire-gnawing	Persistent bar-chewing. A standard welfare indicator in small rodents, not a personality trait.
Stereotypy	A repetitive behavior with no apparent function, used as a measure of poor housing quality.
Sand bath	A dish of dust-free, non-clumping sand a hamster rolls in to manage coat and skin oils. A species essential.
Scatter feeding	Hiding food around the enclosure instead of using a bowl, to engage natural foraging and hoarding.
Solitary	Naturally living alone. Syrians are strictly solitary as adults and must be housed alone.
Lab block	A nutritionally complete formed pellet, the recommended diet base over a loose seed mix.

Compiled from veterinary and small-mammal welfare sources, including the bedding depth research cited on pages 5 and 9 and the large-scale hamster health and mortality study behind Section 03, and cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an exotics-experienced veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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